A mixed vegetable potage (soup) like this is traditional French family fare. It is ladled out of a tureen into wide shallow bowls as a starter all over the country.

french country soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 45 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
AT THE END OF STEP 2

1 tbsp sunflower oil or peanut oil
2 tbsp butter
3 large leeks, cleaned and chopped
1 large floury potato, coarsely cubed
2 large carrots, chopped
3¼ cups vegetable stock or chicken stock
2 bay leaves
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
½ cup hot water

1 Put the oil and half the butter in a large sauté pan over medium-low heat. Add the leeks, potato, and carrots and cook, stirring frequently, for 5 minutes. Reduce the heat a little, add the stock and bay leaves, then season lightly with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Cover and cook gently, stirring occasionally, for 30 minutes or until the vegetables are very soft.

2 Let cool for several minutes, then lift out the bay leaves. Transfer the soup to a blender and process until smooth. Strain back into the pan through a sieve, using the back of a wooden spoon to push through as much as possible. Pour the hot water through the sieve to extract as much as you can from the vegetables.

3 Reheat gently, stirring frequently. Taste and adjust the seasoning, then stir in the remaining butter and serve very hot.



POTATOES
Getting some of the less common varieties of potato is one of the great benefits of shopping at farmers' markets or belonging to a co-op or CSA. The same goes for many other kinds of vegetable, too.